

Learning and Development Policy

Northwind Systems GmbH

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Owner: People Operations

Classification: Internal

Review cycle: Annual

1. Purpose

Northwind Systems invests in the capability of its employees because the work changes faster than any hiring cycle can keep up with. This policy sets out what the company funds, what it does not, how much is available per person, and how requests are approved.

It applies to all employees who have completed their probation period. Requests from employees still within probation are considered on a case-by-case basis with department head support.

2. Annual Development Budget

Each employee has an annual development budget of **EUR 1500**.

The budget runs with the calendar year and is not carried into the following year. It is pro-rated for employees joining part way through the year and for part-time employees.

The budget covers direct costs only -- fees, registration, materials and examinations. Travel and accommodation associated with an approved activity are handled separately under the business travel and expense reimbursement policy and do not consume the development budget.

Where a genuinely valuable opportunity costs more than the individual budget, the balance may be funded from the department training budget with department head approval. This is expected to be occasional rather than routine.

3. Approval

Every use of the development budget requires the line manager's approval in advance. There is no self-service entitlement to spend it, and there is no category of activity that is pre-approved.

This applies equally to attendance at an external conference or professional event, to a paid training course, to a certification examination, to a subscription learning platform, and to a book or publication.

The line manager considers the relevance of the activity to the employee's current role or agreed development direction, the cost against the remaining budget, and the timing against team commitments. A decision is expected within ten business days.

Additional approval is required in three cases:

- Any single activity costing more than EUR 1000 additionally requires department head approval.
- Any activity involving travel outside the employee's country of employment additionally requires the travel authorisation set out in the travel policy.
- Any activity requiring more than five working days away from normal duties additionally requires department head approval.

3.1 How to request

Submit the request in the learning portal, with the activity, the provider, the dates, the total cost and two or three sentences on the expected benefit. Approval is recorded there and forms the authorisation Finance needs when the cost is claimed or charged.

Requests submitted after the event has taken place are not approved retrospectively other than in exceptional circumstances agreed by the department head.

3.2 How costs are paid

Where possible, the provider invoices Northwind directly; the learning portal issues the purchase reference once the request is approved. Otherwise the employee pays and reclaims through the expense tool, attaching the approval reference, or charges it to a corporate card where they hold one.

4. What the Budget Covers

- Attendance at external conferences, summits and professional events, including registration and workshop fees.
- Instructor-led training courses, whether delivered publicly or privately.
- Professional certifications, including the examination fee and one resit.
- Subscriptions to online learning platforms.
- Professional body membership where it is relevant to the role.
- Technical and professional books and publications.
- Language tuition where the language is relevant to the role.
- Coaching, where agreed with People Operations.

5. What the Budget Does Not Cover

- Formal degree programmes. These are considered separately as an education sponsorship and require Executive Board approval.
- Activities unrelated to the employee's role or agreed development direction.
- Equipment and hardware, which is requested through the IT service desk.
- Mandatory compliance training, which the company funds centrally outside this budget.

- Team social events.

6. Time Away From Normal Duties

Time spent on an approved activity during working hours is working time and is not deducted from annual leave.

The guideline is up to five working days per year for development activity. More than that is possible where the case supports it, and requires department head approval as set out in section 3.

Attendance at an approved event outside normal working hours -- an evening or weekend conference -- does not create an entitlement to time off in lieu, but managers are asked to be flexible in the following week.

7. Certification Commitment

Where the company funds a certification costing more than EUR 2000, the employee agrees to remain with Northwind for twelve months from the date the certification is awarded. If they leave voluntarily inside that period, the cost is repaid on a pro-rata basis from the final salary payment.

This condition is stated on the approval and must be accepted before the cost is committed. It does not apply where employment ends through redundancy or at the company's initiative.

8. Sharing What Was Learned

Anyone attending an external event or completing a substantial course is asked to share what they took from it -- a short session for the team, a written summary on the internal wiki, or a contribution to an engineering guild meeting. This is an expectation rather than a condition of approval, and it is the main reason the budget is worth what it costs.

Conference materials and recordings are added to the learning portal where licensing permits.

9. Internal Learning

Alongside the individual budget, the company runs internal learning at no cost to it:

- Engineering guilds meeting monthly by discipline.
- A monthly internal talk series, open to all.
- A mentoring programme, matched twice a year through the learning portal.
- Access to the company's online learning subscription, available to everyone without a request.

10. Relationship to the Performance Review

Development objectives are agreed in the performance review cycle and are the natural starting point for deciding how to use the budget. Use of the budget is not itself a performance measure, and a decision not to use it in a given year carries no consequence.

11. Related Documents

- Performance review process
- Business travel and expense reimbursement policy
- Corporate credit card rules
- New joiner orientation guide